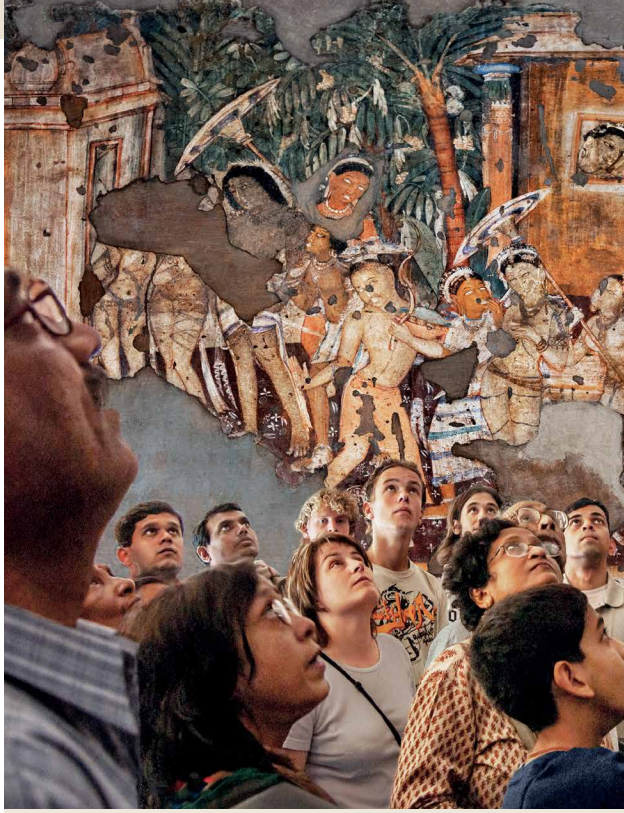
cients, washing away the sins of the past, warding off the dangers of the present. People like Manager Rajdeo Singh, the grey eminence of conservation chemistry who did an extended open heart surgery on 2,200-year-old artwork over a painstaking decade. Or from among the faceless infantry, Milan Chauley, whose feisty tenure as superintending archaeologist, Aurangabad circle, came to an abrupt end with a phone call from New Delhi this January—applauded when he cleared the Bibi ka Maqbara of encroachments, guillotined when he quoted the same rulebook to the Jains who had taken possession of three caves at the back of Ellora. Or the solicitous D.S. Danve, who was part of the Ta Prohm tree temple restoration team in Cambodia, and remembers every date, every bulb that has to be changed. The ASI has profound flaws: a tendency to insularity, and a shambolic sarkari air, especially at the top where it interfaces with government (since 1993, its 13 chiefs have been mostly bureaucrats). But it has also built up a self-learnt repository of knowledge and method at its base layer. A humorous architectural trope fills the Ajanta-Ellora world: ungainly dwarf figures carved at the bottom of edifices, in aspects of superhuman effort, gasping and impossibly arched over as they hold up the tonnes overhead. The field archaeologist might well be a modern analogue of those little men.

DESPITE EXPERTS USING MANY LIFE-SAVING PROCEDURES IN THE PAST TO SAVE THE AJANTA MURALS, SARKARI SLOTH AND DECREPITUDE HAVE TAKEN A SERIOUS TOLL

Beginning 1990, a Japanese-funded, Unesco-guided initiative saw a series of life-saving procedures being performed on Ajanta. Optic fibre illumined the four mural-rich caves; new water channels along the roof helped drain away monsoon excess, minimising mural-killing seepage inside and the peril of falling boulders outside; barricades came up around the murals by 2014; two causeways and a bridge decoagulate and disperse tourists over those 850 metres end to end, a bit more if you toss in the stroll across the river. The nearest airport got new wings. Roads that wheezed along the same ancient network on which caravans once rolled in from Gandhara, Amaravati, Ujjain and the coast—and felt as ancient—got a new coat of macadam. For a while, it seemed as if the old world of Ajanta would be enrobed in sleek modernity. But India doesn't take long to revert to type: a layer of sloth, decrepitude and institutional adamance can settle over every new initiative like fine summer dust.

A latent foreboding eventually enters every conversation on the murals, as if everyone senses the imminence of the end, or at least of its ever-present possibility. Beneath the hum of business as usual, even the sunniest reading seems darkened in its corners by suppressed alarm. That old phrase—optimism of the will, pessimism of



WHY SAVE AJANTA?

Like spokes on a hub, all answers to that question converge on one point: nodality. Whichever prism you see it through—art, political history, or religion—Ajanta is irreplaceable, as both symbol and substance, as riddle as well as revelation. Conservator Sanjay Dhar opens up the first trail. "It's the mother lode of all Asian art. It is *the* place," he says. Imagine that same centrality in the history of power in the subcontinent, and of its religion. That's the treasure trove of signs we have been bequeathed.

Start with art. We can see Ajanta forming a vital node in a caravan trail of echoes all the way from Sigiriya in Sri Lanka to the Mogao Caves at the far end of the Silk Road in China, to the murals at Horyuji, one of Japan's Seven Great Temples. "All of Asia is in debt to that one place," says Dhar. This need not entail parenthood. We do not know if Ajanta was the first Buddhist painted art in India, or the only one of its type, but it's the only such extant ensemble. Stylistic and thematic comparisons between its own two phases, and with the other hubs of ancient art—Mathura, Gandhara, Nagarjunakonda—and western India's